Scrolling Past Democracy: Journalism's Challenge Against Youth

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Introduction

In a robust democracy, a well informed population is essential, amongst youth in particular. In prior years, Generation Z were widely viewed as the future change makers of the world. In recent years, however, there has been a major shift in the direction of news avoidance among youth. Growing disengaged from traditional news sources, youth have been increasingly gravitating towards short-form social media content to stay up to date. This shift has the potential to completely unroot journalism's primary democratic functions: information, public forum, and democratic education in particular. If modern-day journalism fails to engage with the times, today's youth risk being misinformed, polarized, or absent from civic life. As potential funders, you are uniquely positioned to help support innovative strategies to reinvigorate the younger generations' passion for change by advocating for quality journalism.

Problem Description

Social media becoming the primary agent of news for youth has caused an array unprecedented changes to the way in which journalism functions. Studies have shown that people aged 18-24 overwhelmingly rely on social media sites such as Instagram, TikTok, and Twitter as their main gateways to information rather than seeking it from traditional sources (De Corniere & Sarvary, 2021). These platforms are where short-form content reign supreme, which has led into the issue of incidental news consumption, the act of news viewership purely by chance. In the modern environment of news sharing, young people often encounter headlines while scrolling for entertainment, rather than engaging with news intentionally. Increasing trends of a "news-finds-me" mindset among youth have emerged in which young people no longer feel the need to seek out journalism on current events as it is believed that they will be exposed to it eventually through their feed by the act of news sharing among friends through the form of reposting and

“for-you” feed curation (Vazquez-Herrero et. al, 2022). However, as youth become increasingly trusting of the news they incidentally see online, the trust for fake news and disinformation are also on the rise.

Problem Causes

With the culture of sharing one’s life and experiences on social media for others, it is only natural that the frequent sharing of news would be a natural consequence. With the constant sharing, liking, and reposting of content, it is natural for one to stumble upon amounts of information that can seem impossible to synthesize. Studies have shown that higher levels of attention to short-form media content for news have eventually led to increased levels of news information overload, or better known as news fatigue (Lee et. al, 2017). News information overload describes the negative and drained emotional state one can enter from consuming too much news, in particular negative news.

Another issue that may arise from gathering news purely from social media sites is the cycling and spreading of false information. Short-form content is the perfect breeding ground for fake news. In one survey, more than one-third of subjects have admitted to previously sharing a news story that they saw on their feeds without reading the full content (usually only the headline) or fact-checking the article with secondary sources (Vazquez-Herrero et. al, 2022). This is particularly problematic when coupled with the increasing rates of Gen Z’s current “news-finds-me” mindset, as more often than not the news they are seeing being reposted onto their feed has not been fact checked and may lack credibility.

Problem Consequences

The issues of news information overload and the spreading of misinformation have the potential to have drastic effects on Gen Z's future abilities to become engaged in democratic society, as these issues have raised concerns of withdrawal from civic participation and polarization. Studies indicate that higher levels of news information overload have been associated with news selectivity, less frequent future news exposure, and even complete news avoidance (Lee et. al, 2017). This means that the very platforms designed to connect youth to information are instead pushing them away from sustained engagement with current events. This can eventually lead to lower levels of political knowledge among youth, which can have consequences such as lower levels of voter turnout, less mobilization against injustices, and a lack of skills to allow them to fully participate in civic society in general.

The spreading of fake news can also have disastrous consequences toward the unity of younger generations, as jaw-dropping headlines being flung have been shown to cause increased levels of polarization. Young people's reliance on their own curated feed to provide up-to-date information puts them at risk of entering an echo chamber of one-sided ideals, which has led to increased political polarization and "us vs. them" mentality (Mehlman-Brightwell et. al, 2024). When misinformation spreads unchecked, it not only creates a false sense of being informed, but also deepens ideological divides. Polarization as a consequence of misinformation leaves young people less willing to engage with opposing perspectives, putting journalism's role as a shared public forum at risk. Rather than fostering dialogue, news consumption on social media can harden divides, creating echo chambers that weaken democratic cohesion against common disparities. When the public is focused against becoming enemies with one another, it can allow larger societal issues to slip through the cracks, leaving society even more uninformed than they were to begin with.

If left unaddressed, the vicious cycle of overload, avoidance, and misinformation risks leaving the next generation both disconnected from journalism and distrusting of the process of democracy itself.

Conclusion

The challenges facing youth engagement with journalism are not minor inconveniences but critical threats to democracy's foundation. As Gen Z becomes increasingly reliant on fragmented, short-form news content on social media, they face increasing risks of misinformation, polarization, and civic withdrawal that undermine journalism's ability to provide reliable information, foster public forums, and cultivate democratic education. Addressing these challenges will require the reassessment of the current journalistic system as a whole to make it more widely accessible to the youth of consume and fully understand in order to preserve the integrity of journalism as a field. Through investing in new, innovative strategies, investors can help in playing a crucial role in maintaining not only the future of journalism, but the future of the youth as a whole to become leaders and active participants in democratic society.

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